Language Style and Decision Adaptation: A Model-Based Exploration of Contextual and Speaker-Specific Effects

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This project asks whether exposure to a speaker's language style influences decisions across a conversation or primarily in interactions with that speaker. Motivated by Kronmüller and Guerra [1], we consider how their distinction between contextual and speaker-specific adaptation might apply to aspects of language style beyond referential consistency. We are also interested in how these effects develop with experience and whether they persist or change when a previously encountered style is withdrawn and later reintroduced.

We plan to use computational modeling and simulation in an adapted referential-choice task. By varying interaction histories while keeping task-relevant information comparable, we will examine changes in decisions involving the speaker whose style is manipulated and other speakers. We will vary when the style appears and its proportion within the preceding context, followed by periods of neutral interaction and renewed exposure. These comparisons may help distinguish patterns associated with the broader conversational context from those associated with individual speakers.

Our analysis will focus on the magnitude and persistence of decision changes across these conditions. We hope to assess how alternative accounts of adaptation describe the observed patterns and develop hypotheses about the role of language style in human decision-making. Comparisons with existing behavioral evidence will guide interpretation and inform possible follow-up human experiments.

References

[1] Edmundo Kronmüller and Ernesto Guerra. 2026. Adapting Pragmatic Interpretation in Multiparty Conversations: Mutual Exclusivity Inferences across Speaker and Context. *Language and Cognition* 18 (Jan. 2026), e43. doi:10.1017/langcog.2026.10086